

Product Discovery, Market & User Research

Assignment Submission

Scenario:

WhatsApp is the most widely used communication platform in India, deeply embedded in urban and semi-urban households.

Beyond personal conversations, WhatsApp groups have become the default tool for societies and neighborhoods to coordinate local needs—plumbers, electricians, domestic help, pet services, and more.

Today this behavior is widespread but informal, unstructured, and dependent on social availability. WhatsApp is exploring whether it can enable trusted, efficient, community-driven local service discovery without becoming a traditional marketplace.

As a Product Manager, the task is to evaluate this opportunity and outline a structured approach to understanding the problem space before proposing solutions.

Part 1: Market Research & Competitor Analysis

Market Context:

WhatsApp is widely used across urban and semi-urban India. Society and neighborhood groups serve as micro-communities for coordinating local services such as plumbers, electricians, domestic help, tutors, and pet services. This service discovery behavior is informal and chat-based.

Nature of the Market:

- High frequency of local service needs.
- Mix of recurring and urgent requirements.
- Low to mid-ticket transactions.
- Strong dependency on trust and community validation.
- Convenience and speed are valued over price comparison.

Competitor Landscape:

Formal Marketplaces (e.g., Urban Company, Justdial, Sulekha)

Strengths:

- Structured listings
- Ratings and reviews
- Clear service categories
- Booking and payment systems

Weaknesses:

- Less hyperlocal trust
- Transaction-focused rather than community-driven
- Perceived higher pricing
- Limited emotional connection

Informal Community Channels (WhatsApp Groups, Word-of-Mouth)

Strengths:

- High trust factor
- Social validation from known members
- Hyperlocal relevance
- Immediate conversational response

Weaknesses:

- Not searchable
- Repeated service requests
- No structured record of recommendations
- Risk of spam and clutter
- Dependent on active participation

Opportunity Observation:

The gap lies not in basic discovery, but in structured trust, persistent recommendations, and reduced repetition within community-based discovery systems.

Part 2: User Interviews & Insights

Research Objective:

To understand how users currently discover local services, identify pain points in WhatsApp-based discovery, examine trust dynamics, and understand challenges faced by residents, admins, and service providers.

Target Interview Groups:

Residents:

- Working professionals
- Homemakers
- Frequent service users

Society Admins:

- Group moderators
- Resident welfare members

Local Service Providers:

- Plumbers
- Electricians
- Domestic workers
- Tutors

Interview Approach:

- Semi-structured interviews
- Focus on recent real experiences
- Identify emotional and behavioral triggers
- Observe repeated patterns in service discovery

Key Questions:

For Residents:

- How did you find your last service provider?
- What frustrations do you face in society groups?
- How do you evaluate trust?

For Admins:

- How often are service requests repeated?
- Do vendor promotions cause moderation issues?
- What challenges exist in managing group discussions?

For Service Providers:

- How do you acquire customers?
- Do you rely on word-of-mouth or platforms?
- What challenges do you face digitally?

Key Insight Themes:

1. Trust is community-driven.

2. Past recommendations are hard to rediscover.
3. Similar service requests are repeatedly posted.
4. Recently mentioned vendors gain higher visibility.
5. Admins experience moderation fatigue.